CERNO GLOBUS

FIELD INTELLIGENCE

Issue 004 Monday, September 28, 2026 · Biweekly, 4 pages

Home Services

Pest Control · Septic & Sewer · Landscape · Pool · Appliance Repair · Moving

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

IN THIS ISSUE

PEST CONTROL
EPA closed registration review on 20 pesticide cases on September 17 because every product in them is already canceled, among them the rodenticide alpha-chlorohydrin.

SEPTIC & SEWER
EPA and the Army Corps reopened Clean Water Act jurisdiction on September 9 with a supplemental "waters of the United States" proposal; comments close October 9.

LANDSCAPE
EPA pushed the comment deadline on its glyphosate open-literature search from September 24 to November 23, delaying the human health risk assessment the search feeds.

POOL
PHTA and the International Code Council published ANSI/PHTA/ICC-2 2026 on September 16, the public pool operations and maintenance standard health departments write into code.

APPLIANCE REPAIR
Commerce set a 56.43% preliminary dumping margin on seamless refined copper pipe and tube from Mexico's largest producer on September 21, using adverse facts available.

MOVING
Commerce preliminarily found on September 22 that compacted graphite iron brake drums from China circumvent existing orders, exposing them to a 150.25% antidumping rate.

BACKGROUND SIGNAL
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

Read it online
This issue, and every one before it

MONEY

The Federal Reserve raised its benchmark rate a quarter point to 3.75-4.00% on September 16, its own projections showing one more increase before year-end.

The FOMC voted 12-0 on September 16 to lift the federal funds target range to 3-3/4 to 4 percent, effective September 17. Interest on reserve balances went to 3.90% and the primary credit rate to 4.00%. The bank prime loan rate, the index under most small-business term loans and lines of credit, stood at 7.00% in the Federal Reserve's September 25 H.15 release, with the effective funds rate at 3.88%.

The Committee said inflation "remains elevated" and that it acted to support "a timelier return" to its 2 percent goal, while calling activity solid and unemployment little changed. The median projection released the same day puts the funds rate at 4.1% at the end of 2026 and 4.1% again at the end of 2027 - one more quarter-point step this year, no cut next year. Median PCE inflation is 3.7% for 2026 and 2.3% for 2027.

For a home-services company the bill lands in three places: floating-rate debt that reprices inside a billing cycle; new truck, excavator and equipment paper written off a higher prime; and customer financing for the jobs that need it - pool shells, septic replacements, whole-house appliance swaps, full-yard renovations. NAR put August existing-home sales at a 3.98 million annual rate, down 2.0% on the month, with the 30-year mortgage averaging 6.67%.

Nothing in the statement or the projections points to relief inside the next four quarters. The exposure is the discretionary half of the job list and anything a homeowner finances. Escalation language and deposit terms written in 2025, when the market expected cuts, are now stale, and quote validity periods written at 60 days are carrying rate risk you are not being paid for.

What to do about it: Pull every loan, lease and line of credit this week and mark which are floating and off what index - prime, SOFR or a bank internal rate - then recompute the monthly cost at prime 7.00%. Call your lender and ask two things in writing: the rate today, and what it takes to fix it for 36 months. Re-quote any equipment order you have not signed; a truck, excavator or vac unit financed now carries a higher payment than the one you budgeted in spring. If you offer customer financing, get the current buy-rate sheet in writing and rework your payment illustrations, because the old ones understate the payment and will cost you closes. Build steel, copper and parts escalation into 2027 bids and shorten quote validity from 60 days to 30. Do not plan on a 2027 cut; the Committee's own median shows none.

Federal Reserve issues FOMC statement, September 16, 2026 · FOMC Projections materials, September 16, 2026 · Federal Reserve H.15 interest rates, Sept 25, 2026

PEST CONTROL

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

EPA closed registration review on 20 pesticide cases on September 17 because every product in them is already canceled, among them the rodenticide alpha-chlorohydrin.

Why it matters: EPA's September 17 notice (91 FR 58897) ends registration review for 20 cases - including alpha-chlorohydrin, methyl-parathion, ferbam, citral and the mosquito larvicide Lagenidium giganteum - on the ground that all products in each case are canceled. Canceled means you cannot legally distribute or sell the product, and in most cases cannot hold or apply it. Several cases carry no docket at all because registrants withdrew before any assessment began. This week: run that active-ingredient list against your chemical inventory, service-vehicle stock and label library, and get anything on it off the truck before a state inspector finds it.

EPA closes pesticide review cases, 91 FR 58897 (Sept 17)

DEMAND

NPMA published the 2026 Pest Management Standards for Food Processing and Handling Facilities on September 1, the first full revision of the document since 2016.

Why it matters: The 2026 edition rewrites what a food-plant auditor expects to see: current IPM practices, new US and Canadian food-safety requirements, updated FDA and Health Canada allergen lists, and fresh sample inspection reports and risk-assessment templates. Optional practices moved to a separate resource guide, so what remains is what an auditor can hold you to. If you hold food-processing, warehouse or commissary contracts, your documentation and your technicians' certificates are now measured against the new text. Order the 2026 study guide, book the exam for technicians on those routes, and reissue site risk assessments on the new templates before the next third-party audit.

NPMA updates food safety standards, PMP (Sept 1)

SEPTIC & SEWER

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

EPA and the Army Corps reopened Clean Water Act jurisdiction on September 9 with a supplemental "waters of the United States" proposal; comments close October 9.

Why it matters: The supplemental proposal (91 FR 57284) would require a relatively permanent water to flow year-round, with dry spells no more than 30 days, and would require a continuous surface connection of perennial water before an adjacent wetland is federal. It also reworks ditches, waste treatment systems, prior converted cropland and groundwater exclusions. For an installer, that separates a routine drainfield or sewer-line job from a Section 404 permit with delay and mitigation cost. The November 2025 proposal drew roughly 220,000 comments. Comments close October 9 and no hearing is scheduled: file on the site conditions you actually work in, and re-check pending jobs sited near intermittent channels.

"Waters of the U.S." definition, 91 FR 57284 (Sept 9)

SUPPLY

Commerce issued antidumping and countervailing duty orders on steel concrete reinforcing bar from Bulgaria, Egypt and Vietnam on September 18, with margins up to 136.57%.

Why it matters: The September 18 orders set antidumping cash deposits of 53.27% for Bulgaria, 34.20% for Egypt (52.73% for El Marakby Steel and Suez Steel) and 123.49% to 131.53% for Vietnamese producers, alongside countervailing duty orders for Egypt and Vietnam. Scope is rebar in straight length or coil, any metallurgy, length, diameter or grade; plain rounds are excluded. Liquidation is suspended on entries from March 13, 2026. Rebar is priced into cast-in-place tank slabs, pump stations and the precast you buy, so quotes move before your next dig. Ask suppliers in writing for country of origin and the duty component on open orders, and put a steel escalation clause in unsigned bids.

Commerce, rebar AD: Bulgaria, Egypt, Vietnam (Sept 18) · Commerce, rebar CVD: Vietnam, Egypt (Sept 18)

LANDSCAPE

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

EPA pushed the comment deadline on its glyphosate open-literature search from September 24 to November 23, delaying the human health risk assessment the search feeds.

Why it matters: EPA's September 28 notice extends comment on docket EPA-HQ-OPP-2009-0361 by 60 days, to November 23, 2026, "to allow for further meaningful input from stakeholders." That search decides which published studies enter the new glyphosate human health risk assessment, and the assessment is what any future label change, buffer or use restriction will be built on. Nothing on your label changes today; the decision slips and the uncertainty you are pricing into 2027 renewals lasts longer. If you apply glyphosate on turf, hardscape edges or beds, put your own use and exposure specifics on the record before November 23 - rates, PPE, re-entry - rather than leaving the file to litigation science.

EPA, glyphosate literature search extended (Sept 28)

LABOR

USCIS said on September 12 that the 33,000-visa first-half FY2027 H-2B cap filled on September 4, and no supplemental allocation for FY2027 has been announced.

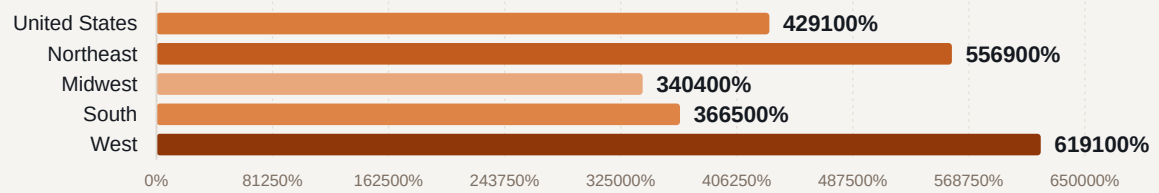
Why it matters: USCIS set a final receipt date of September 4 for the 33,000 first-half FY2027 cap, which covers start dates from October 1, 2026 through March 31, 2027. Any new cap-subject petition with a start date before April 1, 2027 is now rejected, closing the winter window for anyone not already filed. The separate 33,000 second-half allocation covers start dates on or after April 1, 2027. USCIS has not said whether FY2027 supplemental visas will exist, so do not budget on them. This week: confirm receipt notices on anything filed before September 4, start prevailing-wage and ETA-9142B work for April 1, 2027 starts, and plan the winter on domestic hiring and overtime.

Visas Update, H-2B cap reached for FY 2027 H1 (Sept 12)

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / WHAT THE HOUSE IS WORTH

Median existing-home price by region in August 2026, against the national median

Median price of existing homes sold, US dollars; NAR Existing-Home Sales, released September 10, 2026



Regional price spreads decide what a homeowner authorizes without financing. A $619,100 West median supports a full equipment replacement out of pocket; a $340,400 Midwest median does not. Price the same job differently by market, and put a financing option in front of every Midwest and South quote. NAR Existing-Home Sales Report Shows 2.0% Decrease in August (Sept 10, 2026)

POOL

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

PHTA and the International Code Council published ANSI/PHTA/ICC-2 2026 on September 16, the public pool operations and maintenance standard health departments write into code.

Why it matters: The 2026 edition covers water vessels, mechanical systems, chemical treatment systems, decks and ancillary spaces at public pools, spas and aquatic venues. The committee pulled specific water-quality values out of PHTA-2 and now points to ANSI/PHTA/ICC-11 instead, so the numbers your technicians test to live in a different document. That is a paperwork problem first: service logs, operator training material and contract scopes that cite PHTA-2 clause numbers for water quality now point at text that no longer exists. Reprint commercial log sheets and CPO training references against the 2026 edition and PHTA-11 before spring inspections.

PHTA and ICC publish updated PHTA-2 standard (Sept 16)

REGULATION

PHTA opened a 45-day public review on September 18 of a revised PHTA-13 water conservation standard adding leak detection, evaporation and water reuse requirements.

Why it matters: The revision of ANSI/APSP/ICC-13 covers residential and public pools, spas, portable spas and swim spas, and adds requirements and guidance on evaporation mitigation, leak detection and response, water-conditioning devices, and water reclamation and reuse. Practices that were optional move out of the standard into a separate resource guide, so what remains is what a water authority or plan reviewer can cite. In drought-restricted jurisdictions this becomes the text behind fill permits and cover mandates. The review runs 45 days from the September 18 ANSI Standards Action listing. Comment through PHTA's public comment page if leak-detection or reuse language would change how you build, fill or service.

PHTA opens review of PHTA-13 water standard (Sept 18)

APPLIANCE REPAIR

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

Commerce set a 56.43% preliminary dumping margin on seamless refined copper pipe and tube from Mexico's largest producer on September 21, using adverse facts available.

Why it matters: The September 21 preliminary results for the November 2024 to October 2025 review assign Nacional de Cobre a 56.43% weighted-average margin for failing to submit information Commerce required; the review was rescinded for Golden Dragon and IUSA. Copper tube is sealed-system stock - line sets, driers, suction and liquid lines - and Mexico is a primary source. A preliminary rate that high points to higher cash deposits and a higher landed cost at your distributor once final results issue. Case briefs are due 14 days after publication. Price sealed-system repairs off current distributor quotes rather than last quarter's, and get lead times in writing before you commit to a flat-rate sealed-system job.

Commerce, copper pipe from Mexico, AD review (Sept 21)

DEMAND

Existing-home sales fell 2.0% in August to a 3.98 million annual rate while inventory reached 1.62 million homes, the highest since November 2019.

Why it matters: NAR's September 10 release puts August sales at a 3.98 million annual pace, down 2.0% on the month and 1.2% on the year, with months' supply at 4.9 from 4.6 and the median price at $429,100. Fewer closings means fewer of the service calls that cluster around a sale: inspection-driven repairs, warranty work, and the replace-or-repair decision a new owner makes in the first 90 days. With 1.62 million homes listed, sellers carrying time on market are the ones who pay to repair rather than replace. Point fall marketing at repair-to-sell work and at the 30-year-old installed base, and do not build a Q4 plan on move-in replacement volume.

NAR, existing-home sales fell 2.0% in August (Sept 10)

MOVING

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

Commerce preliminarily found on September 22 that compacted graphite iron brake drums from China circumvent existing orders, exposing them to a 150.25% antidumping rate.

Why it matters: The September 22 preliminary determination treats CGI brake drums from China with an inside diameter of 14.75 to 16.6 inches and weight over 50 pounds as later-developed merchandise covered by the existing brake drum orders. The China-wide antidumping rate is 150.25% and the all-others countervailing rate 11.94%, and liquidation is suspended on entries from January 27, 2026 - retroactive to drums already invoiced or on your shelf. Those are straight-truck and tractor drum sizes, a moving fleet's routine brake job. Case briefs are due 14 days after publication. Get origin and metallurgy in writing on drums quoted now, and reprice brake work in the maintenance budget.

Commerce, brake drums from China, circumvention (Sept 22)

MONEY

Commerce opened dumping and subsidy investigations on September 14 into linear hydraulic cylinders from five countries, with alleged margins as high as 744.85%.

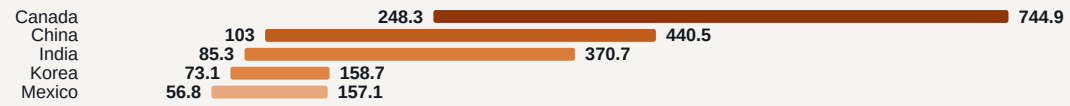
Why it matters: Petitions from the Hydraulic Cylinders Fair Trade Coalition allege margins of 248.33-744.85% for Canada, 103.05-440.48% for China, 85.31-370.67% for India, 73.09-158.74% for Korea and 56.79-157.12% for Mexico. Scope covers steel-barrel cylinders with a bore of at least one inch and retracted length of at least four inches, plus barrels, piston rods and attached parts - the liftgate, tilt-bed and ramp hardware on a moving fleet, new and replacement. Nothing is owed yet; duties attach at Commerce's preliminary determination, due within 140 days of initiation. Buy the liftgate cylinders and rebuild kits you know you need before that determination, and get country of origin in writing.

Commerce, hydraulic cylinders, 5 countries, LTFV (Sept 14) · Commerce, hydraulic cylinders, 3 countries, CVD (Sept 14)

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / CYLINDER DUTY RISK

Alleged dumping margins on linear hydraulic cylinders, low to high, by country of origin

Petition allegations, percent, in Commerce's initiation notice of September 14, 2026 (91 FR 58060)

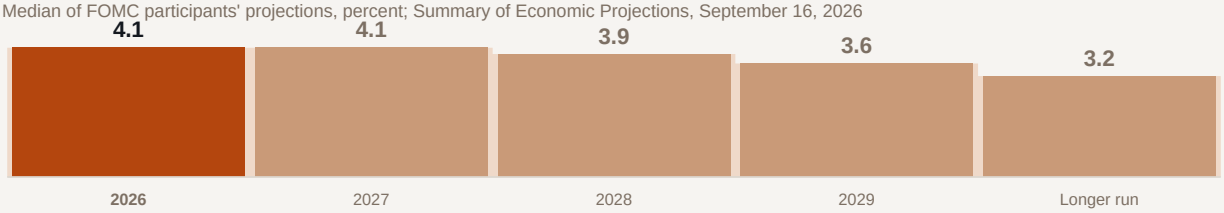


These are petitioners' allegations, not duties owed; Commerce sets the first real rate at its preliminary determination, due within 140 days of the September 14 initiation. Every band starts above 56%, so no listed origin is a hedge. Check origin on liftgate, tilt-bed and excavator cylinder orders now. Certain Linear Hydraulic Cylinders: Initiation of LTFV Investigations, 91 FR 58060

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / WHERE RATES GO

The FOMC's own median path for the federal funds rate, year-end 2026 through the longer run

Median of FOMC participants' projections, percent; Summary of Economic Projections, September 16, 2026



The median holds one more quarter-point increase in 2026 and no cut in 2027. Equipment paper and lines of credit priced off prime, 7.00% in the September 25 H.15 release, should be underwritten for two more years at or above today's level rather than for a 2027 refinance. Fix rates where you can. FOMC Projections materials, September 16, 2026

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

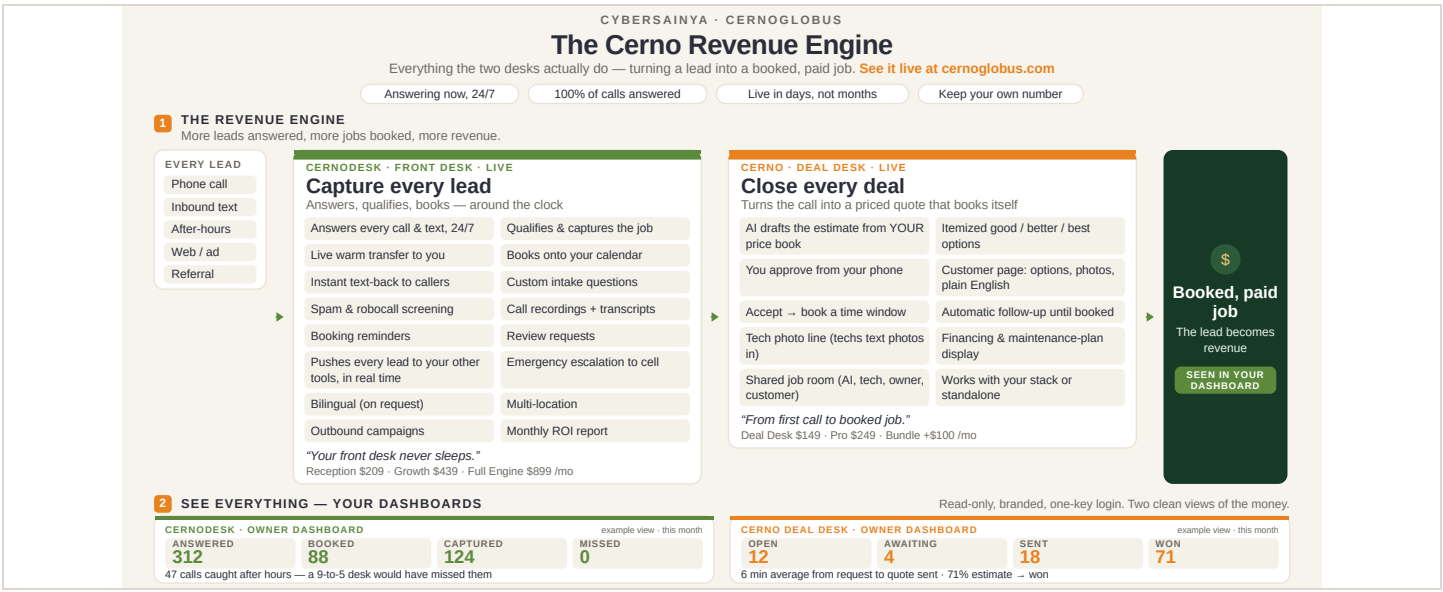
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of $3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to $2.77 billion in 2024 from $2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and $20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern a home services operator. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A trade that emails estimates, service tickets and supplier invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from $2,946,830,270, $2,770,151,146 and $3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.



FREE FROM CERNOGLOBUS

Wary of AI? Start where it falls over.

Module 1 of **AI for Business Growth** is free to read — no signup, no card.

What AI is good for in a trade business, and where it breaks. Seven modules, $149. · cernoglobus.com/ai-for-business-growth

Questions? Reach out.
Corrections, tips, or something you want covered next.
info@cernoglobus.com

The Revenue Engine
See both desks running, and the pricing

AI for Business Growth
Module 1 free — no signup, no card

Subscribe
Get this brief every other Monday

CernoGlobus
Who publishes this brief, and what we build